



## HIDDEN MENACE

Ice expands as it freezes, so it weighs less than the same volume of liquid water. This is why an iceberg floats. But the difference in weight is only 10 percent, meaning that 90 percent of a drifting iceberg is hidden beneath the ocean surface. The hidden ice may also project far beyond the visible ice above the waves.



## FLOATING ISLANDS

Enormous icebergs calve from the vast Antarctic ice shelves.

In March 2000, for example, an iceberg the size of the American state of Connecticut split from the Ross Ice Shelf. These immense slabs of ice float flat in the water, and are called tabular icebergs. They look like icy islands, and in the past many have been mistaken for real islands.

## SLOW DECLINE

As they drift at sea, icebergs start melting into strange shapes. Their weight distribution changes, so they may tip over or even turn upside down. This often reveals the green algae that have been growing on the ice beneath the waterline, as well as dark streaks of rock debris. Some end up stranded on the shore, and slowly collapse like decaying fruit.

### ◀ END OF AN ICEBERG

*Beached on the coast of the Antarctic Peninsula, this iceberg is in the last stage of its life.*

